

located, etc. They tried to convince me that statisticians were not responsible for these aberrations, which come from people in the social sciences who apply statistical methods without understanding them (something I verified later, in formal experiments, to my great horror, as we will see further down).

The second change of regime came with the crisis of 2008. I kept getting invited to debates, but I stopped obliging, as it became hard for me to hear complicated arguments and restrain a smile, sometimes a smirk. Why a smile? Well, the vindication. Not the intellectual vindication of winning an argument, no: academia, I discovered, does not change its mind voluntarily, except perhaps in some real sciences such as physics. It was a different feeling: it is hard to focus on a conversation, especially when it is mathematical, when you have just personally earned several hundreds of times the annual salary of the researcher trying to tell you that you are “wrong,” by betting against his representation of the world.

A Desert Crossing

For I had undergone a difficult psychological moment, after the publication of *The Black Swan*, what the French call *traversée du désert*, when you go through the demoralizing desiccation and disorientation of crossing a desert in search of an unknown destination, or a more or less promised land. I had a rough time, shouting “Fire! Fire! Fire!” about the hidden risks in the system, and hearing people ignore the content and instead just criticize the presentation, as if they were saying “your diction in shouting ‘Fire!’ is bad.” For example, the curator of a conference known as TED (a monstrosity that turns scientists and thinkers into low-level entertainers, like circus performers) complained that my presentation style did not conform to his taste in slickness and kept my lecture on Black Swans and fragility off the Web. Of course, he subsequently tried to claim credit for my warnings voiced before the crisis of 2008.*

Most of the arguments offered were that “times are different,” invoking “the great moderation” by one Ben Bernanke (chairman of the Federal Reserve at the time of writing) who fell for the turkey-before-Thanksgiving trap of not understanding that moving into Extremistan comes through a drop in daily volatility.

Also when I was railing against models, social scientists kept repeating that they knew it and that there is a saying, “all models are wrong, but some are useful”—not understanding that the real problem is